

Scandal in SRINAGAR

Politicians, bureaucrats, policemen. All are named in the sensational 2006 case.

■ A 15-year-old girl made sensational revelations in May 2006 about a scandal involving top politicians, police and security officials.

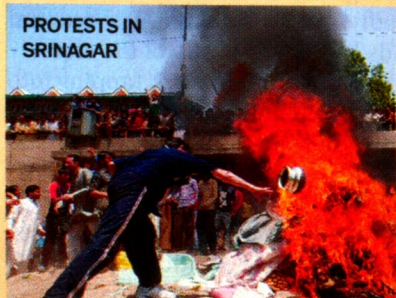


SABEENA

■ A former call girl-turned-madame, Sabeena, who lured several teenagers into the sex trade was arrested soon after. The Valley saw violent protests and enraged crowds attacked Sabeena's house.

■ Investigations showed that several influential people, including two former ministers of the coalition government and senior party functionaries, three SPS and a handful of businessmen, were involved. The CBI took over later.

■ The CBI arrested 18 accused, including two MLAs, a former minister, one senior bureaucrat and a top BSF officer. The Srinagar High Court Bar Association resolved that none of its lawyers will appear for the accused. The trial subsequently shifted to Chandigarh where 11 of the accused were granted bail.



(LEFT) PDP CHIEF MEHBOOBA MUFTI WITH OPPOSITION LEADER AND FORMER DEPUTY CHIEF MINISTER MUZAFFAR HUSSAIN BAIG

THE BITTER TURF BATTLE BETWEEN THE MAIN POLITICAL PARTIES MAY DESTABILISE THE STATE YET AGAIN.

elaborate plans to take its soft separatism into the state Assembly. The party had sent 13 resolutions, based on its self-rule doctrine, to be admitted for discussion in the current session. The Speaker rejected 11 resolutions on the ground that these were outside the purview of the state legislature. Analysts say it became an immediate provocation for a frustrated PDP to hit back at the NC. Also, they took a cue from the NC's belligerent attitude on the first day of the ongoing session and the party displayed its intentions to take them by their horns. Mehbooba even accused the Speaker of behaving like a "NC worker".

The NC on the other hand has struggled to respond to the PDP's theatrics centred round its neo-separatist rhetoric and has clubbed them with "anti-national separatists". Recently, when a three-year-old boy was killed by suspected militants in southern Pulwama district, Omar accused the Opposition

party of maintaining double standards, in the same breath as he accused the separatists for not reacting the same way as both had at the time of the Shopian incident.

In this bitter battle of one-upmanship between the two rival state parties, the NC is just beginning to come to terms with another state level contender to power, a situation that the oldest political party in the state did not have to deal with until 2002, when the PDP was born. An important fallout of this emerging power struggle in the state is that most of the energy of the ruling party goes into maintaining its hold on power rather than focusing on the immediate issues of the state. It may be some time before the governor finally decides on Omar's resignation, but it will be a pity if the chief minister, whose election had generated considerable hope among the people, spends his time thinking up ways to fight the charges of sleaze instead of addressing governance issues. ■